

# Attention deficit hyperactivity disorder

Inattentiveness, hyperactivity, and impulsiveness are the main symptoms of the mental-health disorder known as attention deficit hyperactivity disorder, or ADHD. It usually appears in early childhood, but symptoms may increase from the ages of six to 12 and persist into adulthood.

The main symptoms of ADHD include impetuosity, difficulty concentrating, a “short fuse,” disorganization, prioritization issues, trouble multitasking, and being extremely active or restless. While attention deficit disorder (ADD) shares similar symptoms, ADD sufferers are less hyperactive, and their main problem is an inability to concentrate.

ADHD symptoms can improve with age, but many adults who have been diagnosed with the condition as a child may continue to experience problems throughout their lives. Such difficulties often become evident in the workplace, where an employee has to comply with routines and rules; in this scenario, a person with ADHD may perform less well than would normally be expected.

Additionally, people with ADHD may also experience additional problems, such as sleep and anxiety disorders.

## What causes ADHD?

Because ADHD is a developmental problem that appears to run in families, researchers suspect that there is some genetic basis for the disorder. If genetic faults are to blame, they are likely to be complex and involve more than one gene. The condition has been linked to fetal impairment caused when a mother smoked or drank alcohol while pregnant. Being born prematurely or coming into contact with toxins such as lead in early childhood can also trigger ADHD.

People with ADHD often have learning difficulties (see p.215), although these are not necessarily

**CAN CHANGES  
IN DIET HELP PEOPLE  
WITH ADHD?**

Some parents report behavior spikes after certain foods are eaten, but there is no clear evidence that ADHD is caused by diet or nutritional issues.

linked to intelligence or ability levels. Research has revealed biological and structural differences, including a smaller size and lower blood flow, in the brains of people with ADHD compared to those of people without it. Some studies show that brain chemicals such as dopamine may be lower than normal in those with ADHD.

**MEN ARE THREE  
TIMES MORE LIKELY  
THAN WOMEN  
TO BE DIAGNOSED  
WITH ADHD**



| SYMPTOMS OF ATTENTION DEFICIT HYPERACTIVITY DISORDER                                                                                                                                                                                                               |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
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| <b>HYPERACTIVITY</b><br>Hyperactivity is the term used for someone who is abnormally or extremely active. A hyperactive person is very restless, easily distracted at school or work, and often cannot sit still for more than a few seconds or minutes at a time. | <b>INATTENTIVENESS</b><br>Inattentiveness is associated with ADHD. It is defined by behaviors such as a lack of focus, failure to notice the needs of others, or being preoccupied and not capable of giving sustained attention to the matter at hand. | <b>IMPULSIVITY</b><br>Impulsivity is characterized by actions carried out without any forward planning or awareness of immediate or future consequences. Impulses can be related to emotional situations and physical activity and can seem to be involuntary. |
| <b>Difficulties sitting still</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  | <b>Concentration difficulties</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                       | <b>Frequently interrupting</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| <b>Constant fidgeting</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          | <b>Clumsiness</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       | <b>Inability to take turns</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| <b>Talks more loudly than others</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                               | <b>Easily distracted</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                | <b>Talking excessively</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| <b>Little or no sense of danger</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                | <b>Poor organizational skills</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                       | <b>Acting without thinking</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
|                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    | <b>Forgetfulness</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |